NORTHBANK MEDIA LAB · 2026 STUDY

Signal & Noise 2026

How social media talked about LLMs, Jan–Sep 2026

Hand-coded sample: 387 posts · 6 platforms · 10 themes

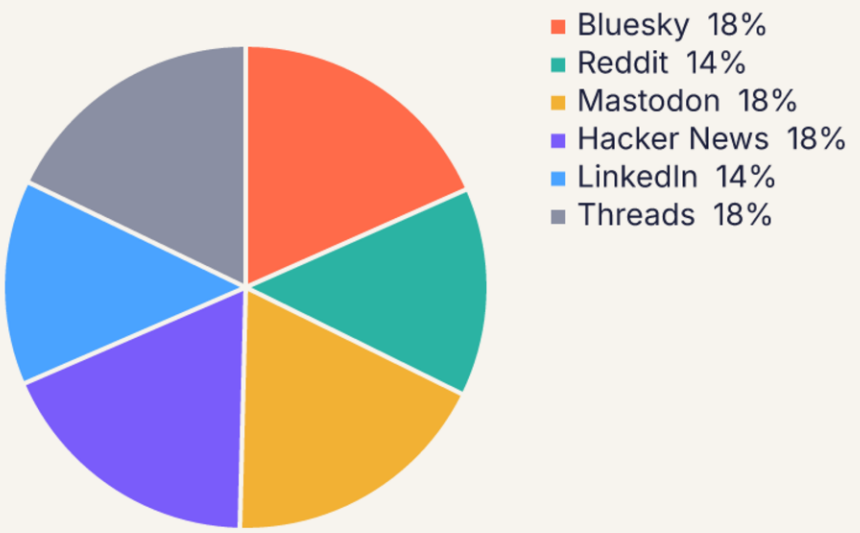


Illustrative study. The data is synthetic. Authors are fictional. There are no real quotes or release claims.

METHOD

A hand-coded sample, reported as shares

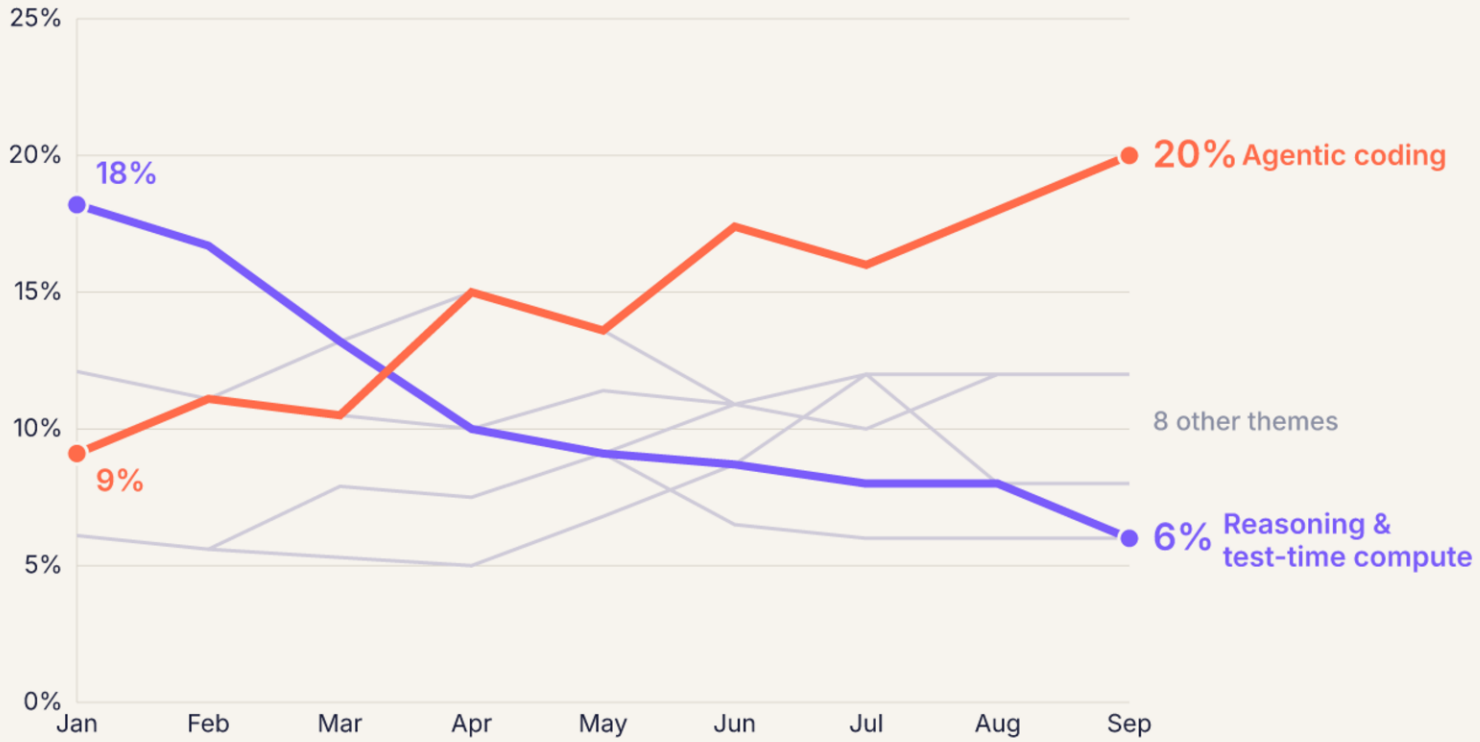
- We hand-coded 387 synthetic posts from Jan–Sep 2026.
- The sample represents a much larger stream of posts.
- Each post has 1 of 10 themes and 1 sentiment: positive, neutral or negative.
- We report shares, not counts: a theme's share of the conversation in a month.
- We also report the share of each theme's posts that are negative.



Sample by platform (chart: VectorCraft)

FINDING 1

Agentic coding doubled its share of the conversation

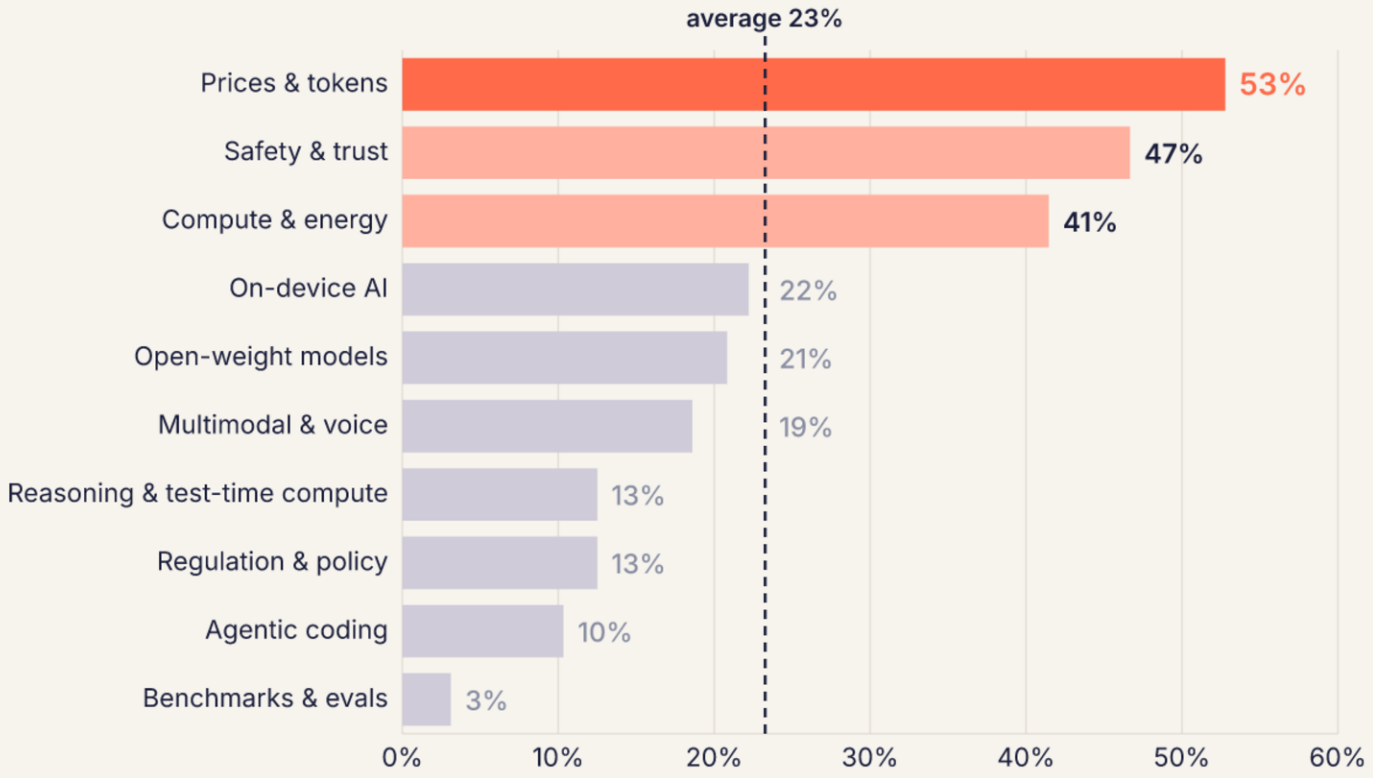


9% → 20%

Agentic coding's share of the conversation, Jan to Sep. It is the largest theme overall, with 15% of all posts.

FINDING 2

Prices & tokens is the most negative theme

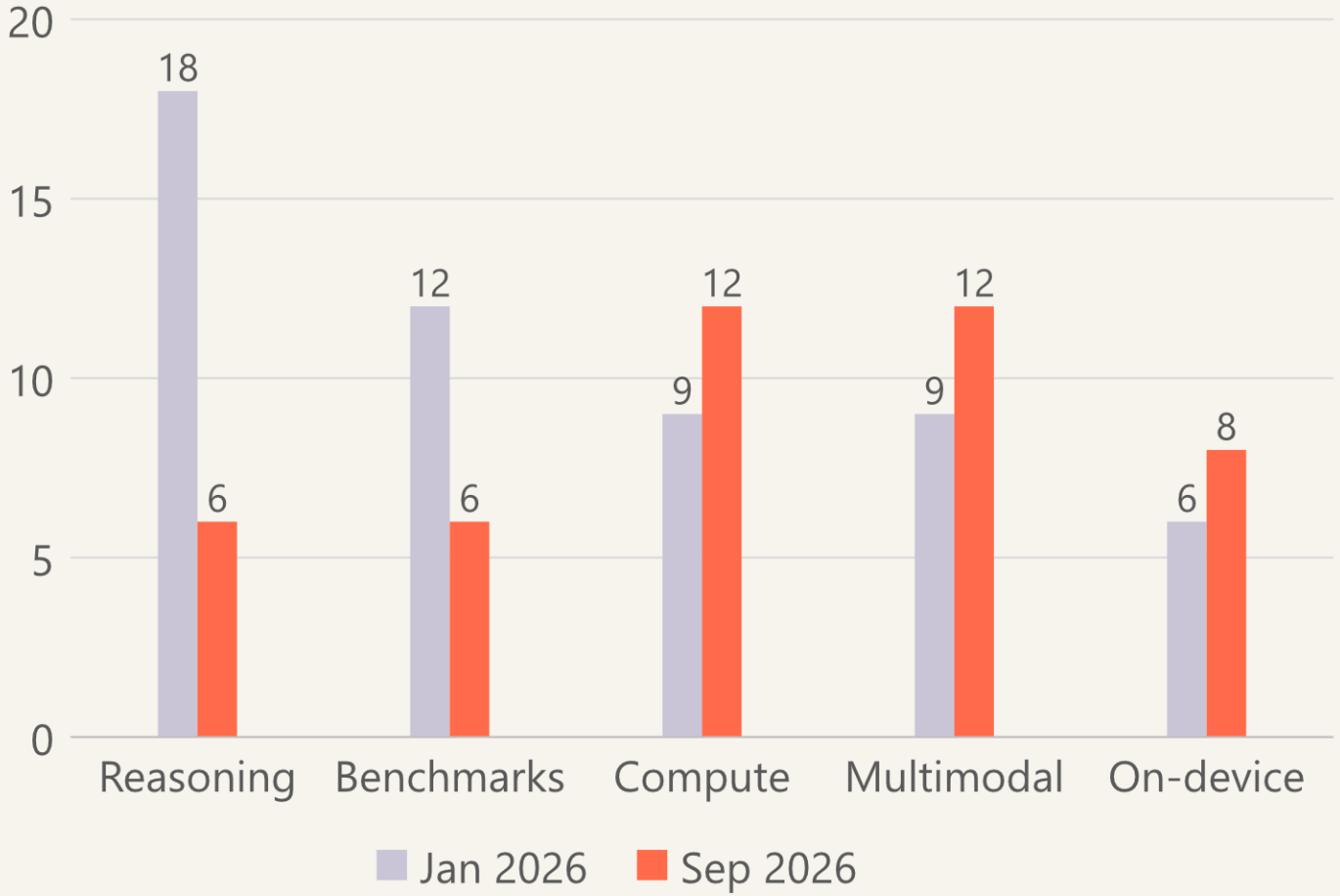


53%

of Prices & tokens posts were negative. The average for all themes is 23%. A frequent complaint: “price per token down, bill up.”

FINDING 3

What grew and what fell



18% → 6%

Reasoning & test-time compute fell from the largest theme to one of the smallest. Benchmarks & evals fell from 12% to 6%.

Share of the conversation (%), Jan vs Sep 2026. Reasoning = Reasoning & test-time compute. Native DeckCraft chart.

TAKEAWAY

The conversation moved from what models can think to what they can do, and to what they cost.

BUILD

Agentic coding's share of the conversation grew from 9% to 20%.

BUDGET

53% of price posts were negative. Posters said bills increased as token prices fell.

GROUND

Compute & energy grew from 9% to 12%. On-device AI grew from 6% to 8%.

ABOUT THE DATA

Synthetic by design

- All 387 posts are synthetic. The fictional Northbank Media Lab made them for this example.
- Authors are fictional handles (@researcher_NNN). No quote comes from a real person.
- The deck makes no claims about real models or companies.
- We show shares because the sample is small. The shares describe the sample only.
- VectorCraft drew the charts and badge. DesignCraft made the poster. DeckCraft made this deck.

